

Columbus Supernatural / Paranormal Experiences — Under \$30 Each

A practical list of haunted lore walks, cemeteries, historic sites, and affordable ghost-tour style outings in and around Columbus. Each core experience is free or caps near **\$30 per person** (before snacks/parking). Lore is local legend — treat respectfully; don't trespass.

How to use

1. Pick **one** outing for an evening or weekend hour.
2. Confirm hours, tour dates, and current ticket prices the day of.
3. Stay on public paths and posted cemetery hours. No private property.

Price key: Free · \$ · \$\$ (still ≤ ~\$30 for the listed experience)

The experiences

1. Green Lawn Cemetery self-guided lore walk — Free

Large historic cemetery with notable monuments and plenty of “quiet after dark energy” during posted hours.

Go for: late afternoon into posted closing (don't stay after hours).

Tip: Download a map pin for the entrance you used; the grounds are easy to get turned around in.

2. Camp Chase Confederate Cemetery — Free

Small, solemn burial ground with heavy Civil War history and strong local ghost lore.

Go for: a short, respectful daylight or dusk visit.

Tip: Keep voices low; this is an active memorial site, not a party spot.

3. German Village brick-street night stroll — Free

Gas lamps, brick alleys, and 19th-century houses — classic “something followed us” storytelling terrain.

Go for: after dinner, slow walk only on public sidewalks.

Tip: Pair with Book Loft browsing earlier; do the spooky loop after dark.

4. Topiary Park / Deaf School Park after sunset — Free

Surreal topiary shapes and open lawn — uncanny more than haunted, which still counts for atmosphere.

Go for: blue hour when silhouettes read strange.

Tip: Stick to lit paths; it's a park, not a jump-scare attraction.

5. Ohio Penitentiary site / Arena District history walk — Free

The old penitentiary is gone; the neighborhood still carries prison-era stories and markers.

Go for: a self-guided block walk reading plaques / old footprints of the site.

Tip: Use daylight first if you're new to the area; night is atmospheric but busier with events.

6. Statehouse exterior night circuit — Free

Capitol grounds, statues, and downtown empty-street energy after evenings.

Go for: after a downtown dinner when the grounds are quiet.

Tip: Stay on public sidewalks/grounds; building tours are separate and schedule-based.

7. Union Cemetery walk (public hours) — Free

Older stones, mature trees, and the kind of silence people write Reddit threads about.

Go for: late afternoon.

Tip: Leave before closing; don't film graves up close without thought for families.

8. Huntington Park / ballpark edge night walk — Free

Built over layers of older downtown; combine river air with “what used to be here” lore.

Go for: non-game nights when it's quieter.

Tip: Check event schedules so you're not paying stadium prices by accident.

9. Short North late gallery-hop + alley loop — Free-\$

Art windows, side streets, and late foot traffic that still feels liminal after 10pm.

Go for: last gallery lights + one alley circuit on public ways.

Tip: Budget \$0 if you only window-shop; coffee optional under \$30 total.

10. Thurber House exterior / Jefferson Ave historic block — Free-\$

Literary history with a slightly uncanny old-house vibe; paid interior programs when priced in budget.

Go for: façade + neighborhood block first; add a ticketed program only if ≤ \$30.

Tip: Verify event fees online before you go.

11. Affordable commercial ghost tour (when listed ≤ \$30) — \$-\$\$

Columbus-area walking ghost tours often land in the \$20-\$30 band — book only when the listed adult price fits.

Go for: a hosted storytelling night so you don't invent routes on private land.

Tip: Screenshot the price before checkout; surge/halloween dates can jump over \$30.

12. Historic tavern lore stop (one drink max) — \$-\$\$

Pick a long-running downtown / German Village / Short North spot with “haunted bar” reputation; one soda or cheap drink keeps you under \$30.

Go for: ask staff for the house story — then leave it at that.

Tip: You're paying for atmosphere + one item, not a bar crawl.

13. Mount Calvary / nearby historic Catholic cemetery visit — Free

Older religious cemetery landscapes; strong mood, low cost.

Go for: daylight respect walk.

Tip: Follow posted rules; no rubbing/climbing monuments.

14. Olentangy / Scioto night path segment (lit sections only) — Free

Water + darkness + city glow — liminal, not necessarily “haunted,” but it scratches the paranormal-outing itch safely.

Go for: a short out-and-back on well-lit public trail.

Tip: Go with a buddy after 9pm; stick to lit stretches.

15. Seasonal haunted house / scare attraction (only if ≤ \$30) — \$-\$\$

Pop-ups and charity haunts sometimes price under \$30 on non-peak nights.

Go for: early-week tickets or matinee-style slots when offered.

Tip: If the gate is over \$30, skip — this guide's rule is hard.

Evening sampler menus

Mood	Pair
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Classic cemetery	Green Lawn → German Village stroll
Downtown lore	Statehouse circuit → Pen site blocks
Hosted stories	Ghost tour (≤ \$30) → one tavern lore stop
Soft uncanny	Topiary Park → Short North alleys

Under-\$30 budget worksheet

Item	Planned \$	Actual \$
Tour / ticket		
Parking		
One drink / snack		
Total (keep experience ≤ \$30)		

Etiquette checklist (non-negotiable)

- ☐ Public property / posted hours only
- ☐ No trespassing for “better footage”
- ☐ Cemetery = respect first, content second
- ☐ Don't harass overnight workers or residents
- ☐ Leave no trash; don't move memorial items

Gear

- ☐ Charged phone + offline map pin
- ☐ Light jacket
- ☐ Portable light (not a spotlight in cemeteries)
- ☐ Buddy for late outings
- ☐ Screenshot of tour ticket if any

After-outing note

Creepiest legit public spot: _____

Best story you heard: _____

Would / wouldn't bring first-timers: _____

Buckeye Trail Guide · Curated by Clayton Householder · Columbus, Ohio

Personal use. Local legend ≠verified haunting. Not affiliated with Metro Parks, the City of Columbus, tour operators, or any cemetery association.

Prices change — confirm before you go.